

MORPHOLOGY & SPELLING

Upper Elementary | Unit 8

Prefixes in-, im-, il-, ir-


Today I am learning that **in-**, **im-**, **il-** and **ir-** can mean **not**.

1 Learn the Meaning

These prefixes are related. In many words, they mean **not**. The spelling of the prefix changes to fit the base word.

incorrect = not correct **impossible** = not possible
illegal = not legal **irregular** = not regular

2 Build the Opposite

Complete the table to build an opposite word.

Base word	Prefix	New word	What it means
complete	in-	_____	_____
patient	im-	_____	_____
legal	il-	_____	_____
regular	ir-	_____	_____
possible	im-	_____	_____

3 Read and Notice

Read the passage below.

Aria was building a marble run for a design challenge. At first, the plan seemed **impossible**. One measurement was **incorrect**, and an **irregular** cardboard piece made the track lean sideways. Her notes were **incomplete**, so she checked them before cutting anything else. Ben became **impatient** and wanted to glue the pieces quickly, but Aria said that would be **irresponsible**. They tested each section instead. One wheel stayed **inactive** because it could not turn freely, and one suggested fix seemed **illogical** because it would send the marble uphill. After correcting the measurement and replacing the **irregular** piece, the run worked. What had looked **impossible** became possible once they slowed down and found the problem.


Highlight the **in-**, **im-**, **il-** and **ir-** words. Underline the base word inside each one.

4 Word Detective

Choose one prefix-family word from the passage and investigate it.

- Write the word from the passage.

- Which prefix does it use: **in-**, **im-**, **il-** or **ir-**?

- What base word do you see inside it?

- What does the whole word mean?

5 Sort the Prefixes

Sort each word by the prefix it uses.

incorrect incomplete impossible impatient illegal
illogical irregular irresponsible

in-	im-	il-	ir-
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

6 Use It in Writing

Complete the sentence starters.

- The plan seemed _____ because _____.

- Use an **in-**, **im-**, **il-** or **ir-** word in your own sentence.



Parent check

Tick the skills your learner has demonstrated.

- ☐ Recognises the **in-/im-/il-/ir-** prefix family
- ☐ Explains that these prefixes can mean **not**
- ☐ Matches the prefix form to a base word
- ☐ Reads and uses derived words in context



Capture idea:

Find an **in-**, **im-**, **il-** or **ir-** word in a book. Write the base word and explain its meaning.